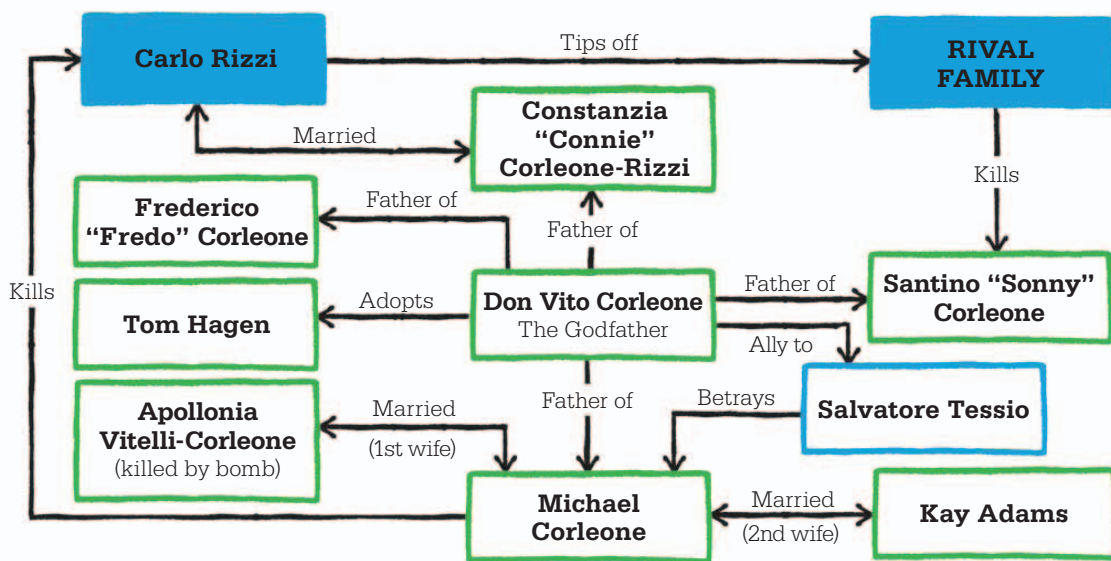




Don Corleone, the Godfather, is at the center of a web of family and associates, bound together by respect, honor—and violent revenge.



Brando was given prosthetic jowls to give him the appearance of ravaged seniority. He was just 48 years old at the time of filming.

Coppola is careful to avoid showing the victims of the family's criminal enterprises—the drug addicts, prostitutes, and ruined families. The only victims of the Corleones' brutality that the viewer sees are the members of rival gangs who posed a threat. And so the viewer sees the Corleones as they see themselves, as a quasi-respectable family fighting to maintain supremacy in a dangerous world, rather than as a bunch of thugs. They have a code of honor, and when Don Corleone finally dies while playing with his grandson in his vegetable garden, we see it as the passing of a giant, the sad end to a titan. The effect is reinforced by Nino Rota's lush musical score, which gives the movie a heroic and tragic feel.

Acclaimed cast

Most telling of all are the remarkable performances from the universally superb cast. Marlon Brando gives an iconic performance as Don Corleone. At the time of the movie's release, there were critics who felt his rasping delivery was affected,

but others maintained that it captured perfectly a man wearied by power and its obligations. Puzo told Brando that he was "the only actor who can play the Godfather." Studio executives were initially wary of the actor's disruptive reputation and box-office credibility, but he won a Best Actor Oscar for his performance.

Although Brando supplies the face of the movie, it is Al Pacino's Michael who carries the story. At the start, he is a college graduate, engaged to a beautiful

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The Godfather changed my life, for better or worse. It definitely made me have an older man's film career.
Francis Ford Coppola